

Foldable phones face their biggest test so far

I have always found foldable phones fun. But, the lack of innovation, average cameras and poor battery ensured that relationship didn't last long. Until, very recently. The foldable phones are back in the spotlight. This past month saw the launch of Samsung's Galaxy Z Fold 7 and Vivo's X Fold 5, two flagship devices that represent the very best of what the foldable phone segment can offer in 2025.

Both are sleeker, smarter and come armed with much-needed upgrades. Yet, they enter the market at a time when sales have plateaued, innovation fatigue has crept in and price tags still carry a premium that makes mass adoption a distant dream.

So the question is: Can foldables finally pass their biggest test: going mainstream?

According to IDC, global foldable smartphone shipments fell by over 25% year-on-year in Q1 2025, marking one of the sharpest declines since their commercial debut. This slowdown isn't because people don't like the concept. Just that they've been stuck in a cycle of incremental updates and premium-only positioning that has stalled their momentum.

Samsung, the undisputed pioneer in this space, has responded with what may be its most refined foldable to date. The Galaxy Z Fold 7 is thinner (just 8.9mm when folded), lighter (215g), and now feels like something you could genuinely carry all day without a second thought. I have been using the Z Fold 7 since its launch and it feels a far superior product than the first foldable phone.

Samsung has also addressed one of the biggest complaints about foldables: the camera. For the first time, the Fold 7 gets a serious upgrade with a 200-megapixel main sensor borrowed from the S25 Ultra, along with a competent 3x telephoto and a wide-angle lens. In a category where camera compromises were often accepted as trade-offs, this feels like a turning point.

Camera is also the reason why I am equally excited about the Vivo X Fold 5. Vivo's foldables have always been known for their



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design finesse and photography. The X Fold 5 continues that trend with ZEISS-backed optics, a robust hinge design, and fast 80W wired charging, something Samsung still hasn't caught up with.

It is a better camera smartphone than most phones available in the market right now. Both these phones are also powered by quite capable chipsets.

Despite the progress, foldables still haven't cleared some critical hurdles.

■ **High Price Tags:** The Galaxy Z Fold 7 costs over Rs 1.75 lacs in India. Vivo's X Fold 5 hits the Rs 1.5 lac mark. These are not prices that encourage mass-market adoption. Until foldables hit the Rs 1,00,000 sweet spot, they'll remain luxury tech.

■ **Durability Anxiety:** Despite advances in hinge engineering and better display protection (Samsung now uses Gorilla Glass Victus 2), many consumers are still wary of long-term durability. That perception is hard to shake without 2-3 years of real-world reassurance.

■ **Battery Life:** Foldables are essentially tablets folded into phones, and yet most of them carry batteries smaller than some mid-range slabs. Samsung's stagnant battery capacity and their slow charging speeds are clear evidence that compromises are still baked in.

Both the Galaxy Z Fold 7 and the Vivo X Fold 5 show that foldables are no longer prototypes – they're polished, premium, and capable devices. Samsung has especially pushed the category forward with real improvements to portability and camera, and its promise of 7 years of updates shows long-term commitment.

But the category itself is at a crossroads. Foldables must now convert admiration into adoption. The novelty factor is no longer enough. The users need more than just 'Wow, it can fold!' Hopefully, these two phones are the start of a new revolution. And hopefully, others follow them soon. **d**